

How to answer 'How are you?' in ADVANCED (C1) English

Tired of always saying, "Fine, thanks"? This lesson will help you break out of that habit and sound more natural—and more advanced—when someone asks how you are. You'll learn everyday responses, more honest ways to share how you're really feeling and a few regional phrases that'll make you sound even more British! Get ready for a lesson filled with example sentences, pronunciation tips and even a quiz to test what you've learnt. By the end, you'll feel more confident answering this common question in a way that suits you and the situation. Ready to mix it up a bit? Let's get going.

Different ways to ask How are you?

Before we get into answering '**How are you?**', let's talk about some different ways to ask this question. There are a lot!

There's nothing wrong with 'How are you?'. It's appropriate in pretty much any situation. But if you're at or trying to reach a C1 level in English, you need to add some variety! So, let's see more ways to ask this question.

You could ask:

- '**How's it going?**'
- '**How're you doing?**'
- '**How've you been?**'

Did you notice the contractions?

- '**How are**' becomes '**how're**' /haʊə/ (with the schwa at the end)
- '**How have**' becomes '**How've**' /haʊəv/ (You'll also hear this pronounced as one syllable - /haʊv/.)

Other common questions you'll hear are '**How's life?**' or '**How's life treating you?**'

You'll also hear '**How're things?**' or '**How's things?**' 'How's things?' isn't grammatically correct because 'things' is plural, but we say it a lot. These

phrases just mean **'How are you?'** or **'What's been happening in your life?'**

You might also ask, **'Been up to much?'** This is more a question about what you've been doing.

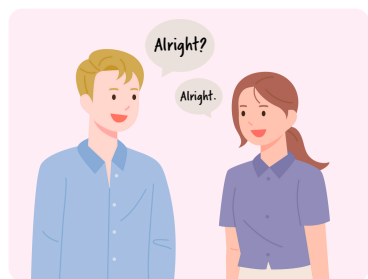
Notice the **ellipsis** in that sentence. We know who the subject is, so we can omit **'Have you'**.

You'll also hear **'You been up to much?'** with just 'have' omitted. You'll hear 'been' pronounced with the long /i:/ sound - **/bi:n/** - and the short /ɪ/ sound: **/bɪn/**.



In grammar, **ellipsis** is when we leave out a word or words because they're understood from the context.

Another informal way to ask 'How are you' is **'Alright?'** This is very British. We're going to talk about responding in more detail in a moment, but the response to 'Alright?' can often simply be **'Alright?'**. Alright (also written as **"all right"**) with the meaning of 'Hello' can be written with a full stop or a question mark. It's similar to saying 'Hi'.



'What's up?' can also be used as an informal greeting with people you know well. You'll often hear it pronounced **'wassup?'** /wɒ'sʌp/ or shortened to **'sup?'** /sʌp/.

Asking 'what's up?' can also be interpreted as 'what's wrong?' when not used as a greeting.

- What's up? You don't look your usual self.

Now, on the other end of the spectrum in terms of formality, we have **'How do you do?'** This is very formal and quite old-fashioned. It's actually a greeting, and we use it when we meet someone for the first time. You can respond with the same words:

- I'm Lucy Simkins. **How do you do?**
- **How do you do?** I'm Mark Wright.

You're not very likely to hear this in everyday conversation anymore.

How to respond to How are you?

First, we need to talk about something that can confuse English learners. Sometimes, when we ask someone how they are or how things are going, **we don't really want an answer.** We call this **phatic communication.** This is language used for social communication rather than to give information or ask questions that require an answer.

It can be difficult to recognise phatic communication when you're learning English. You need to rely on context to know how to respond.

For example, if you're at a conference and you meet a business associate you've only met once before, they might ask, "**How's it going?**" but they most likely won't expect a detailed answer. An appropriate response would be, "**Fine, thanks. You?**" You're not really exchanging any information.

But if you bump into a close friend and they ask the same question, they probably really want to know! You might respond with, '**Not bad, thanks. Actually, I just got a bit of good news!**'

At a Conference

A: How's it going?

B: Fine, thanks. You?

With a Close Friend

A: How's it going?

B: Not bad, thanks. Actually...

Usually, we **answer fairly positively** when someone asks how we are unless we're sure they want to hear about our troubles. We'll start with 3 of the most common ways to respond.

- '**I'm fine, thanks.**'
- '**I'm well, thanks.**'

This one's a little more formal, and we often use it to refer to our health rather than giving a general answer.

- '**I'm good, thanks.**'

People sometimes say 'I'm good' isn't correct, but it's very widely used. It's just considered a bit less formal than 'I'm fine.'

You'll often hear these sentences without 'I'm' -

- 'Fine, thanks.'
- 'Good, thanks'.

This is another example of **ellipsis** — it's obvious who we're referring to.

You'll also hear people answer questions like 'How's it going?' or 'How've you been?' with 'Yeah, good thanks.'.

These aren't yes or no questions, but 'yeah' is a really common filler word and it's a way to quickly acknowledge the question.

Finally, you'll also hear 'I'm doing well/great.' and 'I'm doing good'. 'Doing good' is not grammatically correct, but we use it all the time!

How to respond with British understatement

Now, you might be aware that British people tend to be quite understated, so here are a few more nuanced responses:

- 'Pretty good.'
- 'Not bad.'
- 'Not too bad.'

Yet another common response is 'Can't complain'. This is the same as 'I'm alright.'

In the UK, particularly in the North, you might also hear 'Mustn't grumble'. 'Grumble' means 'complain'.

You'll also hear people say:

- 'Hanging in there.'
- 'Getting by.'
- 'Getting by - just!'

These phrases mean that you're surviving, and so you're fine. They're often used humorously.



But you can also use them more seriously if you're going through a challenging time and you want to answer honestly. **Your tone of voice will be different.**

Another classic understated response is **'Same old'**, or **'Same old, same old'**, meaning that nothing or not much has changed in your life since the last time you spoke with that person. This is a great response to **'How's life?'** or **'Been up to much?'**

Now, after you've responded, you'll probably ask the other person how they are. We very often simply ask **'You?'** or **'Yourself?'**

- Same old! **You?**
- Not bad, thanks. **Yourself?**

Using 'yourself' like this isn't entirely grammatically correct, but it's very common.

You might also ask, **'How're things on your end?'** or 'at your end?' This is more informal.



How to give an honest answer

For our final section, we're going to talk about how to give a more honest answer when you're not doing too well. A common response is:

- **'Been better.'**

or

- **'Been better, to be honest.'**

These sentences also contain an example of **ellipsis** - 'I've' is omitted.

We can also simply say, **'Oh, you know.'** and then continue with more details.

A: How's things?

B: **Oh, you know.** Alan's not well again...

You might also say, **'It hasn't been the easiest week/month etc.'**

'It hasn't been the easiest' is a bit softer than saying, **'It's been the hardest/worst week'.**

A fairly modern phrase is **'It's been a day'** (or week/month/year.) You can also say, **'It's been some day.'** These phrases mean, **'I've had a rough day.'**

And finally, if you're not feeling well, you might say,

- **'Bit under the weather.'**

or, an informal, very British one,

- **'Not too clever.'**

✓ The most positive responses

Here are some of the most positive ways to respond to 'How are you?'

- **Never been better!**
- **Never better!**

🇬🇧 British regional slang

Across the UK, you'll hear lots of different ways to say you're feeling good. These regional expressions are full of character and charm. Listen out for them next time you visit—you might even want to try a few yourself!

- **Liverpool:** **Sound.**
- **Newcastle:** **Canny. / Alreet.**
- **Lancashire:** **Grand.**

✉ Answering 'How are you?' in a work email

Answering 'How are you?' in a work email can feel a bit different. You still want to sound polite and friendly, but it's important to keep things professional. Let's look at a few ways to respond that strike the right tone—warm but appropriate for the workplace.

- **I'm well, thanks.**
- **Things are going well/smoothly.**
- **It's been a productive week so far!**

If you'd like to practise what you've just learnt, click the link below for interactive activities designed to help you use these phrases naturally!

BONUS

➡ [Click here to access the exercises!](#)



Quiz

For each question, choose the correct answer from the options provided.

1. Which of these is an informal British way to ask, "How are you?"

- a) How do you do?
- b) How's things?
- c) How's your availability?

2. Which of these is the most likely phatic expression?

- a) How's it going?
- b) How are your children settling into school?
- c) How's the marketing campaign coming along?

3. Which answer best fits this exchange in a casual setting?

A: "Alright?"

B: _____

- a) Yes, I'm fine, thank you.
- b) Alright?
- c) I've had a tough week.

4. Which phrase would you use to sound understated but positive?

- a) Not bad.
- b) Amazing!
- c) Dreadful, actually.

5. Which of these responses would be most appropriate in a formal email?

- a) Not too clever at the moment.
- b) Hanging in there!
- c) I'm well, thank you. I hope you are, too.

6. Which sentence shows an example of ellipsis?

- a) I am doing very well, thank you.
- b) Not bad, thanks. Yourself?
- c) How've you been?

7. What does the phrase "Never been better!" suggest?

- a) Things are difficult but manageable.
- b) Things are the same as usual.
- c) Things are going quite well.

8. Which of these replies is not technically grammatically correct?

- a) I'm good, thanks.
- b) I'm doing good.
- c) I'm well, thanks.

Answers:

1. b 2. a 3. b 4. a 5. c 6. b 7. c 8. b

